

THE BUSINESS MIX

INITIATIVES	BUSINESS	FEATURE
Biopharmaceuticals	Plasma proteins	Largest integrated producer in South Asia
	Biosimilars	Portfolio of 21 products in the market, 2 to be launched this year and 15 under development—the largest for any company across the world
Pharmaceuticals	Formulations	Later-generation, small molecule oncology focussed
	Active pharmaceutical intermediates (API)	Oncology-focussed
	Key starting materials	For making APIs
	Peptides	Depot formulations
Services	Clinical research	Full service CRO
	Regenerative medicine	Stem cells, cord blood repository
	Molecular medicine	Molecular diagnostics and genetics
Vaccines	Human vaccines	Life-saving and lifestyle
	Animal health vaccines	For cattle and companion animals
Innovative Technologies	Gene therapies	Addressing orphan diseases and unmet medical needs
	mRNA	Vaccines and therapeutics
	Oligonucleotides	Addressing unmet medical needs

SOURCE COMPANY

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to-end. “Starting from research to manufacturing, we are present across the value chain. We took the decision to manufacture everything in-house and that means we can have our team of molecular biologists doing 10 molecules a year compared to, perhaps, one if it was outsourced,” says Venkata Ramana, the company’s Chief Scientific Officer.

In many ways, the Covid-19 pandemic opened up a new world for RLS. “Though we are a biotechnology company, we took the decision to make a contribution. Work on a vaccine started and that is now in phase II [clinical trials],” explains Subramaniam. There were people who questioned the move but he

saw a long-term play. “Covid-19 will be around in some form plus we are trying to integrate that vaccine with the one for influenza.” Besides, RLS did a lot of Covid-19 RT-PCR diagnostics and at the peak, the number was 35,000 samples tested each day. “In terms of products to treat Covid-19 patients, we had immunoglobulin and bevacizumab. We got it right on forecasting demand and repurposed one of our manufacturing facilities to make larger quantities of immunoglobulin,” he adds.

PIECING IT TOGETHER

The Nashik campus will give the company scale, which Dinesh Sathe, the Project Head, estimates will be

four times what it is today. “We are working on a tight schedule and that kind of scale with high levels of productivity can pull down costs.”

With the various pieces falling into place, RLS plans to enter the US biosimilars market later this year. The long-term vision is to create a diverse and deep biotech company. “With our breadth and depth of products, we must be able to make a difference to lives at an affordable cost,” sums up Subramaniam.

For a group that has made a mark in almost every business it has entered, biotechnology could well be the next frontier. **BT**

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